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TheConstructionVoice

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Housing strategy: EBC at 6th High-Level Construction Forum hosted by DG GROW in Brussels

TheConstructionVoice · source

The 6th Annual Plenary Meeting of the High-Level Construction Forum focused on enhancing Europe's construction sector competitiveness and housing strategy implementation. Key discussions addressed economic pressures and the need for innovation, regulatory predictability, and support for SMEs. The event underscored the importance of bridging policy ambition with concrete delivery to tackle the ongoing housing crisis.

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Regulation

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Public procurement: EBC calls for proportionate EU action on subcontracting chains in construction

TheConstructionVoice · source

The European Builders Confederation urges the EU to regulate construction subcontracting chains to support SMEs and combat abusive practices. They highlight the negative impact of excessive subcontracting on SME margins and call for measures to enhance transparency and direct participation in public procurement. Proposed changes include limiting tiers of subcontracting, banning financial subcontracting, and mandating lot division to empower SMEs.

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TheConstructionVoice

Public procurement: EBC calls for proportionate EU action on subcontracting chains in construction

https://www.ebc-construction.eu/news/public-procurement-call-for-proportionate-eu-action-o

Public Procurement: Call for proportionate EU action on construction subcontracting chains to support SMEs in public procurement

In the context of the revision of the European Public Procurement framework, the European Builders Confederation (EBC) calls for proportionate EU action on construction subcontracting chains to tackle abusive practices and unfair competition, improve transparency and support direct SME participation in a new policy note.

Subcontracting is a feature embedded in the construction sector, particularly among SMEs and microenterprises. However, excessive vertical and cascading subcontracting structures raise concerns, as they erode SME margins, weaken business models, reduce the quality of works and working conditions, and increase risks of social dumping, unfair competition and opacity, particularly in public procurement.

While approaches differ across Member States, there is growing convergence among construction SMEs on the need for an EU-level signal against abusive subcontracting practices, while respecting subsidiarity and existing national frameworks.

For this reason, considering the parallel discussions in Brussels on public procurement and subcontracting, EBC sets out the following proposals on construction subcontracting chains to support SMEs and the wider value chain in public procurement:

- Focus EU action on subcontracting chains in public procurement: Make publicly funded contracts the priority area for regulatory intervention justified by risks posed to SMEs, competitiveness, and social conditions.

- Shape an EU limitation targeting abusive vertical subcontracting chains in construction that preserves national flexibility: Introduce a general EU-level principle of limitation of tiers, with requirements and practical implementation defined at Member State and sectoral level.

- Ban financial subcontracting and protect SMEs in cascading chains: Ensure that main contractors perform a meaningful share of the works contracted.

- Facilitate direct SME access through mandatory division into lots: Make lot division the rule rather than the exception, reducing reliance on vertical subcontracting chains and improving direct SME participation.

- Reaffirm the role and proportionate responsibility of actors across the chain: The main contractor should retain overall responsibility towards the client, while subcontractors remain responsible for their own obligations within the chain.

EBC President Jean-Christophe Repon stated: "Subcontracting is common practice in the construction sector. However, cascade subcontracting and excessive vertical chains erode SME’s margins, weaken competition, create dependencies, and undermine transparency, quality and safety conditions-situations that are all the more unacceptable when public funds are at stake. A European approach to address abusive subcontracting practices in our sector is needed, taking into account systems already negotiated and performing at national and sectoral level."

Housing strategy: EBC at 6th High-Level Construction Forum hosted by DG GROW in Brussels

https://www.ebc-construction.eu/news/high-level-construction-forum-2026-dg-grow-dedicates-

High-Level Construction Forum 2026: DG GROW dedicates plenary session to Competitiveness and Housing Strategy implementation

April 30, 2026

The 6th Annual Plenary Meeting of the High-Level Construction Forum (HLCF) brought together EU institutions, Member States and industry stakeholders in Brussels on 30 April 2026 to address the strategic challenges facing Europe’s construction ecosystem. The discussions centred on improving productivity and competitiveness, as well as advancing the implementation of the European Strategy for Housing Construction.

The full-day event, hosted by the European Commission’s DG GROW, was structured around three main pillars: the competitiveness of the construction ecosystem, the transition from strategy to implementation in housing policy, and practical solutions discussed in dedicated breakout sessions.

A key moment of the plenary was the video message by Commissioner Dan Jørgensen, who underlined the central role of the construction sector in achieving Europe’s climate and housing objectives. Highlighting that 85% of buildings were built before 2000 and that 75% remain poorly energy efficient, he stressed that boosting the renovation market represents a major opportunity, particularly for SMEs across Europe.

Competitiveness in a changing economic context

Barbara Bonvissuto, Director at DG GROW, emphasised the need to create a more predictable business environment. She called for simplification and acceleration of permitting procedures, improved access to raw and secondary materials, and the effective implementation of circular economy measures-including the Circular Economy Act- to unlock the Single Market for construction products.

The meeting also marked the formal introduction of Natalia ■ebrowska-Mamais as the new Head of Unit for Construction at DG GROW, signalling continued commitment from the European Commission to strengthening the sector's policy framework.

The morning session explored the broader economic and geopolitical forces shaping the construction sector, with contributions from the European Commission, OECD and industry representatives. Discussions highlighted the pressure of rising materials and energy costs, global housing challenges and the need to strengthen the sector's resilience and productivity. The Chief Economist of DG GROW highlighted that the sector has been facing successive crises since 2015, with lasting impacts on supply chains, costs and investment capacity.

From strategy to implementation: focus on housing delivery

The second part of the plenary focused on the implementation of the European Strategy for Housing Construction, recently presented as part of the EU's Affordable Housing Plan.

In her keynote, DG GROW Director-General Kerstin Jorna stressed that a performing construction ecosystem means a performing local economy. She outlined key priorities for the sector, including simplification, digitalisation and the implementation of the revised Construction Products Regulation (CPR), alongside efforts to create stronger business cases and enhance resilience to geopolitical pressures. She also highlighted the importance of ensuring that construction and housing are fully reflected across the three pillars of the next Multiannual Financial Framework (MFF).

Matthew Baldwin, Head of the European Commission's Housing Task Force, presented ongoing and upcoming initiatives under the Affordable Housing Plan. These include a forthcoming first-ever Housing Summit, a mapping exercise of permitting practices across Member States, and a planned simplification package by 2027. He also pointed to the growing importance of industrialisation in construction and the role of the European Housing Alliance in bringing together public authorities and stakeholders.

From housing strategy to concrete delivery

The second panel discussion brought together representatives from Member States, industry, product manufacturers and workers' organisations, reflecting the diversity of the construction ecosystem.

During the discussion, EBC Secretary General Fernando Sigchos Jiménez raised a key concern regarding the current policy orientation. He stressed that industrialisation should not be seen in

opposition but rather under a complementary approach to traditional construction methods—one that values handcrafted expertise alongside industrial solutions, with continuous support to the current and future entrepreneurs, SMEs and workforce. This is particularly important in a context where the sector must attract new talent with industrial transformation taking time to scale.

The afternoon workshops focused on concrete bottlenecks to implementation, including the simplification of permitting procedures, the uptake of secondary construction materials, and innovation through CPR implementation and offsite construction.

Looking ahead

This HLCF edition confirmed the central role of the construction ecosystem in addressing Europe’s housing crisis while contributing to the green and digital transitions. While policy frameworks at EU level are evolving, the key challenge remains translating ambition into delivery on the ground. In that context, participants underlined that bridging the gap between policy ambition and local on-the-ground delivery will require stronger cooperation, regulatory predictability and simplification, targeted support for SMEs, continued dialogue between the Commission and the construction sector, and a prioritisation of the sector as a strategic industrial sector for Europe’s housing, climate and competitiveness objectives.

EBC looks forward to engaging further with the European Commission and the construction industry representatives, to ensure that SMEs and craft trades are well represented in all strategic fora.